REQUEST FOR BID PROPOSAL
for JA BizTown Simulation Redevelopment

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Table of Contents

CONFIDENTIALITY 4
INTRODUCTION 4
SUMMARY OF PROJECT 4
Project Goal: 4
Redesign Vision and Core Features of the JA BizTown Simulation: 5
Background on JA BizTown 6
Simulation Overview 7
Audience Summary 7
JA BizTown Simulation Day Schedule - Future State 11
Simulation Requirements/Module Requirements 15
Report Access: 17
Gamification Ideas 18
Dashboards 21
Staff/Simulation Dashboard 21
Teacher View 22
PRODUCT DESIGN REQUIREMENTS 23
Summary 23
Overview 23
Process & Methodology: Design Thinking 23
Deliverables by Phase: 24
Product Design Expectations 27
SCOPE OF WORK 29
TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS 30
Summary 30
Infrastructure 30
Mobile Application Development 30
Backend Development 30
Frontend Development 31
Paper-based Version 31
Accessibility 31
Security Data 31
Scalability 32
Boards and Source Control 32

Agile Methodology **33**
Deployment **33**
Administrative Capabilities **33**
Support and Maintenance **34**
Localization **34**
Reporting **34**
Proof of Concept **35**
Documentation **35**
Eligible Applicants **35**
SCOPE & PRICING 36
PROCESS **36**
PROPOSAL SCHEDULE & SUBMISSION PROCEDURES **36**
EVALUATION PROCEDURES 37
Proposal Content and Evaluation Criteria **37**
Interviews **38**
ADDITIONAL DETAILS 38
PROPRIETARY/CONFIDENTIAL INFORMATION **39**
APPENDIX 40
Character Education Moments in Simulation **44**

CONFIDENTIALITY

Note that your receipt of this Request for Proposal indicates that representatives of your organization have read and signed a Junior Achievement confidentiality agreement (Non-Disclosure Agreement). All content in this document falls within the confines of that agreement.

INTRODUCTION

Founded in 1919, Junior Achievement® (JA) is the oldest, largest, and fastest growing nonprofit economic education organization in the world. It is the largest partnership linking the private sector with education efforts. Junior Achievement's educational programs serve as the primary vehicle to advance the organization's purpose and vision: To inspire and prepare young people to succeed in a global economy. Programs are regularly developed, revised, and enhanced as Junior Achievement helps young people understand the economics of life.

Junior Achievement USA has a nationwide presence. It provides content and services to 98 local JA Areas across the country. The JA Areas work with more than 220,000 Volunteers who deliver the content to over 4.6M students.

Junior Achievement ensures the effectiveness and relevance of its economic and business education programs by utilizing validated curricula and instructional materials, specific program implementation standards, teacher and volunteer training, and program outcomes evaluations.
Additional information about Junior Achievement and its activities can be found at https://www.ja.org/ and internationally at https://www.jaworldwide.org/.

SUMMARY OF PROJECT

Project Goal:
Engage with a software development vendor to build a new elementary/middle school simulation software to be used in a hands-on, interactive physical experience where students apply classroom learning by operating businesses, managing money, and fulfilling civic roles in a realistic, simulated community for a day in a physical facility. The physical simulation flow will be shared out by Junior Achievement.

The redeveloped JA BizTown experience will more powerfully reinforce what it means to participate in an economy. Students will clearly see how their actions as employees impact their business, how business decisions influence the broader community, how taxes support civic functions, and how consumers drive economic activity. When employees perform well, businesses succeed. When businesses succeed, communities benefit. When citizens understand taxation and spending, they better grasp civic responsibility. Stronger visual dashboards and real-time feedback tools will make these relationships tangible, helping students internalize the circular flow of the economy in ways that are relevant and memorable.

The redeveloped software will adopt a modern, age-appropriate interface aligned with today's financial applications. The simulation software supports the running of the businesses in the mock town. Digital banking systems, tap-to-pay functionality, and modern processes will reflect real-world financial practices. New student dashboards (such as CEO and CFO student roles) will provide clearer visibility into business performance, empowering students to monitor financial health, track cashflows, and make strategic decisions. Staff dashboards will also be overhauled to support real-time adjustments, clearer reporting, and a stronger overall simulation flow.
The experience will remain adaptable across devices, ensuring compatibility with traditional desktop environments, tablet-optimized implementations, and fully tablet-friendly models for JA BizTown Mobile. This

flexibility provides accessibility and supports expansion into more communities nationwide.

Redesign Vision and Core Features of the JA BizTown Simulation:

The JA BizTown program introduces upper elementary and middle school students to the world of work, business management, and personal finance through an engaging blend of classroom instruction (curriculum) and a hands-on, interactive simulation (field-trip style). The curriculum includes key instructional units—community and economy, work readiness, financial literacy, and business management—culminating in a fully immersive experience where students run an entire town. The simulation can take place in a permanent JA facility or a mobile setup (similar to a pop-up trade show exhibit) hosted in schools, community centers, or other shared spaces.

JA BizTown is a highly interconnected, real-time simulation environment in which approximately 80 to 150 students operate a fully functioning economy for the day. Each student is assigned a specific role within one of roughly 14 to 20 businesses, with 6–8 students per business. Every participant functions simultaneously as an employee, consumer, voter, and citizen within the simulated community.

JA is reimagining the JA BizTown simulation to create a more dynamic, interconnected, and educational experience that better reflects today's workplaces and technology. The new design will include the following key features:

- A unified digital platform that adapts to both onsite and mobile delivery, offering flexible levels of complexity appropriate for elementary and middle school learners.
- Engaging modern simulation that supports the physical simulation where students take on jobs, manage businesses. The software will feel real to them (but age appropriate)
- A storefront-based economy where students manage operations, serve customers, pay expenses, and interact with other businesses to keep their town running smoothly.

The simulation system must support a complex web of interdependent financial and operational transactions. Students earn varying wages based on their assigned roles, apply for and manage loans through financial institutions, maintain individual bank accounts, and conduct purchases across businesses within the town. Each transaction, whether payroll distribution, loan disbursement, retail purchase, or service payment, must update in real time across multiple systems. For example, when a student makes a purchase, the transaction must immediately deduct funds from the student's personal bank account, reflect in the receiving business's account, and record accurately within the financial institution's system. This interconnectedness is foundational to maintaining the integrity and authenticity of the economic simulation.

The redevelopment should strengthen and modernize this integrated ecosystem. Key areas of opportunity include enhanced dashboards for students and staff, improved point-of-sale (POS) systems, robust banking functionality, and transparent financial reporting tools. The system should provide clear, real-time visibility into individual, business, and community-level financial performance while maintaining data accuracy and stability under simultaneous usage.

Additionally, the platform should support a one-device-per-student model to expand interactivity and instructional value. This includes capabilities such as digital voting, online loan applications, dynamic financial tracking, and digital marketing creation and publication within the simulated environment. The infrastructure must enable these features while preserving seamless cross-system communication.

Given the depth of integration required across financial systems, business operations, civic engagement components, and digital content tools, the selected vendor must demonstrate strong full-stack development expertise and experience building scalable, transaction-based systems with real-time data synchronization.

The redesigned JA BizTown ensures students leave inspired and empowered, with a foundational understanding of how the economy works, how their roles contribute to society and their business, and how decision making and leadership can shape their future success.

Background on JA BizTown

JA BizTown is one of Junior Achievement's Experiential Learning Center programs. Junior Achievement's Experiential Learning Center programs combine practical applications in real world situations with principles learned in the classroom. Students discover how an economy functions by taking on real-world roles as citizens and employees, managing businesses, personal finances, and community responsibilities in an interactive, simulated town.

JA BizTown gives 5th–6th grade students the opportunity to experience how a community operates and how personal and business finances are connected. After in-class lessons on topics such as financial literacy, business management, and community, students take on real-world roles as business leaders, employees, and consumers within a simulated town. They manage bank accounts, write checks, receive paychecks, and run their assigned businesses while providing goods and services to their peers. Throughout the day, students complete their job tasks, work to pay off their business loan, and see firsthand how their work contributes to the success of their businesses and community. Volunteers support students as they navigate their roles, offering insight and encouragement to make the experience both educational and inspiring.

The on-site JA BizTown experience is a 4.5-hour simulation led by JA staff where students operate an entire town, taking on roles as business owners, employees, and citizens. Throughout the day, they apply what they've learned in the classroom to make real-world business and personal finance decisions — running their assigned businesses, managing payroll, using debit cards, and participating in the town's economy.
Guided by volunteers and supported by an interactive digital platform, students experience firsthand how jobs, money, and community interconnect. This combination of a physical environment (the immersive town setting) and a cloud-based application allows students to seamlessly engage in business operations, banking, and communications using mobile devices. The result is a dynamic, hands-on experience that brings the world of work and free enterprise to life.

The experience incorporates:

- A physical environment of business storefronts that serve as workplaces, retail stores, and customer service hubs for students running or visiting businesses during the simulation.

Constituents:

- Students – act as business leaders, employees, and consumers, engaging with peers and technology to operate their town.
- JA BizTown Staff – lead the 4.5-hour simulation, typically guiding ~150 students, ~20 volunteers, and ~10 teachers.
- Volunteers – mentor and support students as they perform their job duties, manage finances, and make business decisions throughout the day.
- Teachers – assist students in connecting the day's activities to their classroom lessons and monitor participation.

The storefronts provide:

- A hands-on simulation of real-world business operations and transactions (i.e., applying for business loans, managing payroll, selling products, and paying expenses).
- An opportunity for sponsors to incorporate their brands (i.e., local banks, grocery stores, or utility companies) into the simulation environment.
- Function as workplaces, business headquarters, and hubs for civic engagement.

- Interactive engagement through digital interfaces — such as debit card payments, budgeting tools, and business management apps.

The digital platform (software modules) allows for:

- A detailed and immersive simulation replicating real-world business decision-making.
- Administrative control and customization of content through an intuitive content management system (CMS).
- Seamless sponsor integration with logos, brand assets, and product imagery woven into the experience.
- Interactive dashboards that allow staff to monitor student progress and guide the flow of the simulation.

Simulation Overview

In the JA BizTown experience, the student's objective is to develop work readiness by working in a simulated town with their own business, job, and job tasks.

The steps begin with pre-simulation lessons covering work and career readiness, financial literacy, community and economy, and business management. During the pre-simulation lessons, students also apply, interview, and are hired for the jobs they will have in the simulation.

During the simulation, students work in one of the various businesses (aka storefronts) and in one of the various jobs within that business. They are paid for all of their hard work in the town and can use that money to shop and purchase items in JA BizTown to take home.

Student job tasks can be inside their own business, or they could be doing something in town or at another business. All businesses are interconnected within the JA BizTown economy. Supply and demand plays a huge factor in the success of the businesses in the town.

The experience concludes with reflections about the success of the businesses and the challenges students faced and successes they experienced during the day.

As students go through the simulation - they make the connections to transferable skills, how to grow within their organizations, and how to add value to their organizations.

Audience Summary

The audience for JA BizTown is elementary and middle school students (grades 5-6; age 9-12) across the country. Students complete a minimum of 12 lessons prior to arriving at a facility for their on-site experience. Students are "hired" for their job before they arrive at the facility, but typically do not know exactly what tasks they will be doing all day.

Administrators (Simulation Managers) of JA BizTown set up simulations, create templates, customize/ localize the experience to their community and local sponsors, create job roles and tasks for each business, and lead the students through the entire 4 hour simulation.

Audience Role Types

There are numerous roles involved in the success of this experience.

Simulation Preparation:

- **Local Area Admins**

- Set up and customize simulated experiences with storefronts, jobs, and storefront activities.
- Support volunteer training (though some areas may also have a specific role of Volunteer Trainers)

Day Of:

- **Simulation Managers**
  - Typically, full-time JA Area staff
  - Responsible for -
    - Customizing/localizing CMS
    - Creating simulation templates
    - Setting up and activating simulations
    - Leading day-of volunteer training
    - Leading day-of simulation experience with students, volunteers, teachers, and staff
    - All physical and digital assets in JA BizTown

- **Simulation Specialist**
  - Typically, part-time JA Area staff
  - Responsible for -
    - Preparing and setting up physical simulation space
    - Supporting Simulation Manager with day-of simulation experience with students, volunteers, teachers, and staff
    - Supporting Simulation Manager with all physical and digital assets in JA BizTown

- **Volunteers**
  - Volunteer types
    - Corporate - volunteering as part of their organization
    - Parent - parents of students attending JA BizTown
    - Community - volunteering as part of local community groups (chambers, leadership groups, colleges, etc.)
  - Volunteer roles
    - Mentors and guides students through their JA BizTown day by providing them guidance on their job tasks, answering their questions about what it means to have a job, and adding in their own personal experience to enhance the learning opportunities.

- **Educators**
  - May also be impromptu volunteers
  - Deliver 12 lessons of curriculum prior to the on-site simulation experience
  - Check for understanding with students throughout day and aligning JA BizTown visit to curriculum
  - Monitor student behavior and engagement

- **Students**
  - Elementary and Middle School - 5th through 6th grade
  - Participate in onsite 4hrs simulation where they are led by a JA Staff member on the microphone providing instructions, consult with their volunteers for guidance, and use

what they've learned in the curriculum and recommendations within the software and from their volunteer to make wise financial decisions. Students make all decisions to run a successful business including applying for a loan, submitting payroll, voting, and making purchasing decisions.

Learning Objectives

- Career Readiness & Workplace Skills
  - Students discover the connection between education, training, and career opportunities.
  - Students identify their personal strengths, interests, and skills as they relate to potential careers.
  - Students experience the hiring process, including job applications and interviews.
  - Students understand workplace roles, responsibilities, and the importance of teamwork and communication.
  - Students demonstrate professional behaviors such as time management, accountability, and collaboration.

- Business Management & Entrepreneurship
  - Students learn how businesses operate and compete in a market economy.
  - Students understand the roles of CEOs, CFOs, and employees in running a business successfully.
  - Students develop and implement a business plan that includes setting goals, managing expenses, and serving customers.
  - Students recognize how customer service, marketing, and innovation influence business success.
  - Students experience how supply and demand affect business decisions and profitability.

- Financial Literacy & Money Management
  - Students learn to use a checking account and manage deposits and withdrawals.
  - Students understand how to track personal and business expenses.
  - Students experience earning a paycheck, understanding gross vs. net pay, and budgeting within their means.
  - Students recognize the importance of saving and making responsible spending decisions.
  - Students connect personal and business financial responsibility to business success and community well-being.

- Digital Literacy & Modern Work Tools
  - Students navigate a digital workspace that mirrors modern office tools (email, messaging, project boards, online banking).
  - Students learn responsible and professional online communication.

- Decision-Making & Critical Thinking
  - Students apply problem-solving strategies to challenges that arise in the workplace and economy.
  - Students make informed decisions about spending, saving, and business operations.
  - Students reflect on how their choices affect their business, coworkers, and the larger JA BizTown community.
  - Students recognize that success often depends on collaboration, adaptability, and ethical decision-making.

- Civic & Economic Understanding
    - Students understand the concept of a community as an interdependent system of citizens, businesses, and government.
    - Students recognize how taxes, voting, and civic participation contribute to community success.
    - Students explore how local government supports businesses and citizens through services and infrastructure.
    - Students identify how economic choices affect businesses and the overall economy.

- Community & Citizenship
    - Students understand how businesses and citizens contribute to a healthy, thriving community.
    - Students explore how philanthropy, volunteering, and social responsibility strengthen communities.
    - Students learn to balance personal success with civic duty and shared prosperity.

JA BizTown Simulation Day Schedule - Future State

1. Student Arrival and Welcome

Duration: 15 minutes

Overview: Students are welcomed into the simulation environment and oriented to the expectations, procedures, and logistics for the day. This phase includes a review of safety protocols (restrooms, emergency procedures, lunch procedures, movement expectations), behavioral norms, and device usage guidelines. Facilitators assess student readiness through brief knowledge checks that connect prior in-class instruction to the simulation experience. This ensures students understand both operational expectations and the purpose of their participation in JA BizTown.

Students will:

- Demonstrate understanding of logistical expectations and behavioral norms for the simulation day.
- Activate prior knowledge gained during in-class JA BizTown curriculum lessons.
- Recognize that the simulation is an application-based learning experience, not a standalone event.
- Enter the experience with clarity, confidence, and a shared understanding of expectations.

Simulation Modules Used: N/A

2. Opening Town Meeting

Duration: 15 minutes

Overview: The day formally begins with a structured town meeting led by the Simulation Manager. During this ceremony, leadership roles are acknowledged, including CEOs, public safety officials, educators, and volunteers. Students collectively recite the Citizens' Pledge, reinforcing civic responsibility and shared community values. This gathering establishes the tone of professionalism, responsibility, and community interdependence that will guide the simulation.

Students will:

- Recognize and respect formal leadership roles within a community structure.
- Understand the importance of civic identity and shared responsibility.
- Experience the connection between leadership, governance, and community success.
- Develop an appreciation for public recognition and accountability within structured systems.

Simulation Modules Used: N/A

3. New Hire Orientation

Duration: 30 minutes

Overview: Students transition into their assigned businesses for a structured "New Hire Orientation." During this time, business teams participate in guided introductions, learn about their company's mission and operations, review specific job responsibilities, and discuss workplace expectations. Financial reminders (paychecks, taxes, and financial accountability) are reinforced. A purposeful team-building activity aligned to the company's function helps students understand collaboration within a business context.

Students will:

- Understand the purpose, function, and structure of their assigned business.
- Identify and internalize the responsibilities of their individual job role.

- Develop awareness of professional workplace norms and expectations.
- Recognize the interdependence of job roles and how each contributes to business success.
- Experience intentional team building that reflects real-world workplace collaboration.

Simulation Modules Used: Surveys, Team Building Exercise

4. Trainings

Duration: 20 minutes

Overview: Students participate in focused micro-trainings aligned to essential business competencies: marketing, leadership, customer service, and visual merchandising. These sessions provide practical, actionable strategies that students immediately apply during business operations. Instruction is interactive and scenario-based to reinforce application rather than passive learning.

Students will:

- Understand foundational marketing psychology and persuasive messaging techniques.
- Identify essential components of effective advertising.
- Develop leadership behaviors including delegation, recognition, and accountability.
- Demonstrate effective customer service practices, including professionalism and responsiveness.
- Understand how visual presentation influences consumer purchasing decisions.
- Apply training concepts directly to real-time business operations.

Simulation Modules Used: Digital Marketing Tool

5. Business Opening

Duration: 20 minutes

Overview: Businesses formally prepare to open operations. The Chief Financial Officer (CFO) completes the business loan application process on a shared device interface visible to all team members, reinforcing transparency and collective understanding. Upon approval, the team receives confirmation and proceeds to payroll verification, where employees review and confirm their W-2 information before final CFO submission. Teams then collaboratively determine product price and strategies.

Students will:

- Understand the purpose and implications of securing a business loan.
- Recognize how startup capital supports operational success.
- Demonstrate attention to detail in financial documentation and payroll processes.
- Develop accountability for personal financial information.
- Analyze pricing strategies and understand how price impacts revenue, demand, and profitability.
- Experience shared financial decision-making within a business context.

Simulation Modules Used: Business Loan, Student Payment, Point of Sales System, Student Payroll

6. Lunch

Duration: 20 minutes

Overview: Lunch

Students will: Break for students to eat Lunch (Operational break; informal peer interaction and community building.)

Simulation Modules Used: N/A

7. Sales Strategy Round 1

Duration: 10 minutes

Overview: The Chief Marketing Officer (CMO) leads a structured strategy meeting to prepare for customer interactions. The team establishes sales goals, defines staff roles, and confirms pricing strategies. This planning period encourages deliberate, data-informed decision-making before operations begin.

Students will:

- Practice collaborative planning before execution.
- Develop leadership skills through facilitated discussion and delegation.
- Identify clear sales roles and responsibilities.
- Set measurable goals for customer engagement and revenue generation.
- Understand the importance of strategic alignment prior to operations.

Simulation Modules Used: Digital Marketing Tool, Point of Sale System

8. Business Operations Round 1

Duration: 30 minutes (3 segments of 10 minutes)

Overview: Businesses begin active operations. Students engage in product sales, peer shopping, B2B (business-to-business) transactions, and civic participation (voting). The CEO finalizes loan documentation at the bank. Students may also choose to allocate earnings toward savings. The segmented structure reinforces time management and operational pacing.

Students will:

- Apply marketing, sales, and teamwork strategies in real-time.
- Complete B2B tasks that reinforce inter-business dependence.
- Practice consumer decision-making and personal budgeting.
- Engage in civic responsibility through voting participation.
- Experience the operational rhythm of a functioning economy.
- Strengthen communication, adaptability, and problem-solving skills.

Simulation Modules Used: Point of Sales System, Student Payment (tap-to-pay, debit card), Voting, Business Banking, Student Payment, Billing System

9. Sales Strategy Round 2

Duration: 10 minutes

Overview: Teams analyze performance data from Round 1 and adjust pricing strategies accordingly. A randomized business scenario introduces a decision-making opportunity (e.g., responding to community needs or allocating charitable contributions), requiring ethical and strategic evaluation.

Students will:

- Interpret sales and profit data to inform decision-making.
- Understand how pricing adjustments influence financial outcomes.
- Evaluate trade-offs between profitability and community impact.
- Demonstrate ethical reasoning in business decision-making.
- Experience iterative improvement based on performance feedback.

Simulation Modules Used: Digital Marketing Tool, Point of Sale System, Business Banking

10. Business Operations Round 2

Duration: 21 minutes (3 segments of 7 minutes)

Overview: Businesses implement revised strategies during a second operational round. Students continue sales, shopping, B2B interactions, and civic engagement. This shorter cycle reinforces efficiency, adaptability, and strategic refinement.

Students will:

- Apply lessons learned from prior performance analysis.
- Demonstrate improved strategic execution.
- Complete outstanding B2B and civic responsibilities.
- Strengthen financial literacy through continued earning and spending.
- Experience how adaptation impacts business outcomes.

Simulation Modules Used: Point of Sales System, Student Payment (tap-to-pay, debit card), Voting, Business Banking, Student Payment , Billing System

11. Business Debrief

Duration: 10 minutes

Overview: Businesses conduct a structured end-of-day meeting. Students review performance data, analyze successes and areas for growth, complete a post-simulation survey, and receive a summary report of business metrics (e.g., earnings, XP accumulation, staff performance, income). Each student leads a designated portion of the discussion to reinforce distributed leadership.

Students will:

- Analyze quantitative and qualitative measures of business performance.
- Reflect on decision-making and teamwork effectiveness.
- Practice presentation and facilitation skills.
- Engage in constructive evaluation and continuous improvement thinking.
- Connect actions taken during the simulation to measurable outcomes.

Simulation Modules Used: Business Banking, Leaderboard

12. Business Closing

Duration: 5 minutes

Overview: Students clean and reset their business spaces, ensuring materials are organized and prepared for future use.

Students will:

- Demonstrate responsibility for shared spaces.
- Practice workplace professionalism through proper closure procedures.
- Understand the importance of stewardship and organizational care.

Simulation Modules Used: N/A

13. State of the Town

Duration: 10 minutes

Overview: The Mayor presents voting results and recognizes community achievements. Awards are distributed to top-performing businesses. The Simulation Manager presents leaderboard results and explains the criteria for success, reinforcing the connection between decisions and outcomes.

Students will:

- Understand how civic participation influences community outcomes.

- Recognize characteristics of high-performing businesses.
- Reflect on how leadership, collaboration, and strategic decision-making contribute to success.
- Celebrate achievements within a structured civic environment.
- Internalize the connection between economic systems and community impact.

Simulation Modules Used: Voting, Leaderboard

Note: For JA Areas who do not have the space for all students to go on lunch at once, the Trainings, Lunch, and Business Opening phases will serve as rotations for ⅓ of the JA BizTown businesses.

Simulation Requirements/Module Requirements

Roles will be assigned various modules. Some roles will have common modules and there will be some modules that are specific to one or more roles. The JA BizTown simulation software must include the following modules:

- **Point of Sale system**
  - Setting sale price for products per storefront and should include a slider that shows profit/loss based on sales price and initial startup loan
- **Student payment**
  - Each student tablet will have a QR code that acts as their form of payment
    - When a student's break color is called for their shopping break, their device will switch to their QR code and turn the color of their assigned break (red, yellow, green)
    - Tablets would switch back to their normal job screen when it is no longer their shopping break
  - Software should also have the ability to function with debit cards and debit card swipers
  - Explore ability to use NFC as payment.
- **Digital marketing tool** (similar functionality to Canva, but built into the software)
  - Must also have the ability to share designs between devices, job roles, and businesses
- **Banking system**
- **Payroll system**
  - Ability for Areas to choose direct deposit or print paychecks
  - 2nd paycheck - would be more of a "triggered spot bonus" type setup where the simulation lead can decide to use that as the "2nd payroll" or as a "spot bonus" if they decided to
- **Loan application and approval system**
- **Billing and bill pay system**
- **Team building exercise**
    - leverage software (one-device-per-user) to create a widget for their business all in real-time. This will help them better see, understand, and feel how each of their inputs are critical to the team experience and the overall success of their business and it will engage each student since each NEEDS to play a role.
- **Business scenario**
  - e.g.: town park gets hit by tornado - every business/CEO receives a pop-up asking if their business wants to contribute to repairs. Businesses have the option to contribute or not. Those that do - money deducted from business accounts, but gain a lot of Experience Points (XPs) (because they did the right thing). Businesses that don't contribute, get to keep their money, but lose lots of XPs because they didn't support their community.
    - Allow JA Area to put a pre-defined amount in CMS (possibly have 3 options

available to businesses - "we do not want to contribute", and 2 predefined amounts).
        - Individual student contributions - could pop-up after the CEO provides business contributions. Could pop-up on individual student tablets for them to decide if they want to contribute $1 or $2.
- **Customizable "free space" for JA Areas to add unique tasks**
    - There must be some guidelines within this feature (ie. character limit, design, etc.)
- **Voting capabilities**
    - Kiosk version and mobile version (for Mayor to walk around and take votes on their device)
- **Survey and evaluation integration (pre- and post-)**
        - Ability to lock 4-6 questions to all JA Areas
        - Ability for JA Areas to add up to 6 questions
        - Ability to multiple response types (multiple choice, yes/no, free response)
- **Business dashboard**
    - Spot on the leaderboard
    - Tips to increase the spot on the leaderboard
    - Business transactions
    - Loan amount
    - Items competitors are selling and pricing
    - Profit and loss statements
    - Profit calculator (revenues minus expenses)
    - Pie charts and bar graphs
- **Dashboards**
    - Admin
        - Student reporting view
        - Business reporting view
        - Control the simulation phases
        - Add Experience Points to business accounts
        - Add money to student accounts
        - Add money to business accounts
        - Voting results view
    - Teacher
        - Quick and easy way to access student and business reports
- **Motivational guided tips throughout**
    - "Remember to make a payment towards your business loan! You have $50 in your business account to make a payment towards your loan!"
- **Business leaderboard based on Experience Points (XPs)**
    - Payment toward loan is made
    - Loan is applied for
    - Invoice is paid
    - Bill is sent
    - Payroll is complete
    - Marketing ad was submitted
    - 2 employees in your business voted
    - Open a savings account
    - Employee or business made a donation to the nonprofit organization
    - For every employee that does pre- and post-surveys
    - Cleanest storefront
    - Paid off business loan
- **Onscreen tutorials**
    - Walk students through key steps:

        - Paying a bill
        - Sending a bill
        - Payroll
        - Paying part of a loan
        - POS usage
- **AI**
    - Sale strategy - leverage AI to come up with slogans for their business
    - Transcription - transcribe CEOs speech by having them speak into the tablet and it helps create their speech for them
- **Radio business**
    - Music/radio software integrated into the software with the ability to connect to the facility's A/V system
    - Automatically imports each business's slogan and gives the DJ the ability to choose which slogans they would like to play or read on-air
- **Screen share capabilities**
    - Example: ability for the CFO to use their device to complete the business loan application and for the rest of the business employees to be able to see everything the CFO is doing from their device, but not actively press buttons or type.
- **Evaluation:**
    - The proposed simulation platform must include functionality that allows JA USA staff to configure embedded student response items at both the beginning and the end of the simulation experience. At minimum, the system must support the insertion and editing (including hard-coding, as needed) of at least ten (10) customizable items per survey instance, with space for a minimum of 125 characters per item prompt. The response scale for these items must also be fully editable, allowing JA USA staff to define custom response options. The system must support up to six (6) response choices per item, with space for a minimum of 25 characters per response option. Response scales may include traditional Likert-type formats (e.g., Agree/Disagree) or alternative response themes (e.g., Confident/Somewhat Confident), and must allow flexibility to accommodate varying evaluation needs.

Teacher Role Requirements

Report Access:

At the end of the day, teachers should receive reports on all students who attended JA BizTown. This ensures comprehensive visibility into student progress and the overall experience. The student report should include information on each individual student's success in the simulation, but also each business's success in the simulation. Additionally, reports should be available for voting and evaluations.

These reports can be accessed via QR code or email.

Volunteer Role Requirements

Dashboard Access:

Volunteers should use tablets to access their dashboard, allowing them to visually see student and business success and other relevant information. The dashboard should allow the volunteer to see their business performance including loans, sales, transactions, student pay, student purchases, business transactions, profit and loss statements, pie charts, and graphs. Additionally, the platform must clearly define when and why a volunteer should intervene, minimizing ambiguity.

Volunteer Guide:
The volunteer guide should be integrated into the dashboard, providing sample discussion questions and instructions for group activities. This ensures consistency and helps volunteers create organic conversations with students.

Survey Integration:
Volunteers should be able to complete surveys at the end of the day to provide feedback on their experience. The survey should capture both positive moments and areas for improvement.
User Interface: The dashboard should be designed for tablet use, providing a larger screen for volunteers to see group discussions and interact with students. The interface should be user-friendly and provide clear instructions for volunteers.

Simulation Manager Role Requirements

Centralized Dashboard:
The simulation manager should have a single, centralized view of the town's operational and financial status. The dashboard should show business status (financials, POS transactions, payroll), banking and B2B activity, student role progress, at-a-glance indicators for risk or bottlenecks (payroll hasn't been completed, no loan payments have been made, etc.). The simulation manager should also have the ability to make real-time changes in the simulation from storefront changes, swapping students between businesses, move the simulation forward with actions automatically completing (e.g.: all students payroll submitting if simulation manager decides to move forward).

Admin Intervention Tool:
The simulation manager should be able to correct, adjust, or recover from errors without undermining the student ownership. There should be available admin tools to reverse or edit transactions; reissue paychecks; correct payroll, POS, or banking mistakes from the simulation manager's laptop, without needing to go into each business or touch each machine to make the change.

User Interface:
The dashboard should be designed for ease of use, providing clear visual indicators and allowing the simulation manager to monitor student progress and make necessary adjustments.

Gamification Ideas

Purpose of Gamification in JA BizTown
Gamification in JA BizTown must:

- Reinforce decision-making, accountability, and cause-and-effect
- Reinforce the overall learning
- Increase engagement without increasing cognitive load
- Support accessibility, equity, and shared-device environments
- Enhance—not replace—the human, experiential nature of the simulation

Gamification should reward understanding and responsible choices, not speed, competition alone, or superficial completion.

- **Business Leaderboard**
    - The Business Leaderboard should be an all-encompassing view of the most successful business in JA BizTown and should be live, presentable by the JA Area admin on a large screen, and contain a formula that combines multiple variables.

        - The leaderboard should be based on various factors that represent the business' value:
            - Financial Health
                - What percentage of the business loan has been paid off
                - Profit/revenue the business has made
                - Setting pricing of products based on minimum viable sales price to pay back loan and generate profit
                - How fast the business pays off the business loan
                - How quickly a business has all of their invoices paid
                - Philanthropic contributions a business makes
        - Students should clearly understand why their business is placed at a certain level on the leaderboard and should be given tips to increase their place on the leaderboard.
- **Business-Focused Random Scenarios**
    - The Business-Focused Random Scenarios should teach students the ethical ramifications of business decision making and the choice(s) they make during this random scenario could affect their place on the leaderboard.
        - The Business-Focused Random Scenarios should:
            - be completed by students at a set time so that JA Area staff can plan this time into their day.
            - be specific to the type of business the students are working in.
            - have a clear way for the students to correctly or incorrectly make a decision, but should not be incredibly obvious.
            - should allow for 10-15 minutes of discussion between the students with some volunteer input where needed.
            - should clearly explain the reasoning for the correct answer whether the business gets the answer correct or incorrect.
        - e.g.: town park gets hit by tornado - every business/CEO receives a pop-up asking if their business wants to contribute to repairs. Businesses have the option to contribute or not. Those that do - money deducted from business accounts, but gain a lot of Experience Points (XPs) (because they did the right thing). Businesses that don't contribute, get to keep their money, but lose lots of XPs because they didn't support their community.
            - Allow JA Area to put a pre-defined amount in CMS (possibly have 3 options available to businesses - "we do not want to contribute", and 2 predefined amounts).
            - Individual student contributions - could pop-up after the CEO provides business contributions. Could pop-up on individual student tablets for them to decide if they want to contribute $1 or $2.

- **Business Financial Health Indicators**
    - The Business Financial Health Indicators should be visible, on-screen indicators that are easy for students to see on a shared device.
        - Can be pie chart, graph, some sort of modern visual to easily and quickly understand financial health of business.
    - The Business Financial Health Indicator should reflect:
        - Income versus expenses
        - Loan burden/percentage of loan paid off
        - Predicted loan payoff amount based on sales
    - The Business Financial Health Indicator should provide actionable tips to the business workers to improve their financial health.

Gamifications Delivery Notes

- Use animations to explain abstract concepts
- Include gamification elements that align with learning goals
- Create realistic simulations for business decision-making
- Design reward systems tied to learning milestones (XPs for making good decisions)
- Creative and competitive features to boost engagement
- All gamification elements must function in a high-noise environment and not rely on audio
- Accessibility first gamification design
    - Support English/Spanish at minimum
    - Include visual, text, and optional read-aloud modes
    - Avoid reliance on sound or fast reaction times
    - Be usable on shared devices

Content Management System (CMS)

1. **Overview**

   The CMS will serve as the administrative backend of the JA BizTown simulation platform. It must enable authorized staff to configure, customize, manage, and monitor all aspects of the simulation experience without requiring advanced technical knowledge or vendor intervention.

   The CMS must be easy to navigate, easy to edit and localize, easy to setup, and easy to pull reports. The CMS will enable JA Areas to manage local customization by inputting sponsors, logos, careers, payroll, salaries, and other simulation elements while also creating templates and setting up simulations. The CMS must include the ability to bulk upload the aforementioned items. The system must also support comprehensive, easy-to-generate reporting that allows users to analyze student experiences based on criteria such as simulation type, simulation name, and date.

2. **User Roles & Permissions**

   The system must support configurable role-based access, including (but not limited to):
   - National administrators (super admin)
   - Local site administrators (admin)
   - Local site simulation managers

   Capabilities should include:
   - Customizable permission levels
   - Ability to restrict editing access by site or region
   - Audit logs tracking changes made by users
   - Multi-factor authentication options
   - Ability to rollback changes to a previous version
   - Ability to "copy and paste" existing localized CMSes
   - Ability for national configuration (super admin) and ability to push that down to local JA Areas (admin)

3. **Simulation Configuration & Customization**

   The CMS must allow staff to:

   Business & Job Configuration
   - Add, edit, archive, or duplicate businesses
   - Modify job titles, job responsibilities, and compensation
   - Adjust business capacity (number of employees per business)
   - Customize mission statements and company descriptions

   Financial Variables

- Adjust salary rates
- Modify tax rates and withholdings
- Set pricing for goods/services
- Configure loan terms and interest rates
- Set account balances or starting funds

Student Experience Controls

- Adjust timing of simulation phases
- Enable/disable specific modules (e.g., loans, voting, marketing)
- Configure rotation schedules
- Modify student task lists or checklists

Content Customization

- Edit on-screen instructions
- Modify vocabulary definitions
- Adjust reading levels where applicable
- Upload local branding (logos, sponsor names)
- Add site-specific businesses or sponsors

4. **Multi-Site & Template Management**

The CMS must support:

- A national master template
- Local site-level customization layers
- Ability to push national updates without overwriting local customizations
- Version history and rollback functionality
- Cloning of site configurations

5. **Other requirements**

- Ability to contain 100+ simulations all with the same abilities
- Admins can only access, see, and customize the facilities they are assigned to
- Create simulation templates – quick, easy, and intuitive
- Ability to make changes real-time in the CMS while a simulation is active
- Ability to preview a simulation without having to go through the steps of setting up a simulation
- Ability to see uploaded images without needing to activate a simulation
- Accessibility and language management (at bare minimum - english and spanish)

This is critical for maintaining consistency while allowing JA Area flexibility.

Dashboards

3 types of dashboard - see below for more information.

- Staff
- Teacher
- Volunteer

Staff/Simulation Dashboard

- Should monitor individual student progress
  - Checking account
  - Savings account
  - Purchases
  - Completed activities

    - Voting
- Should monitor business progress
    - Transactions
    - Inventory tracking
    - Amount of loan paid off
    - General financial health
    - Random scenario response
    - Business leaderboard and the formula showing why
- Admin controls
    - Send messages
    - Correct student errors from simulation manager station
        - Correct student names
        - Correct student's payroll
        - Move students around storefronts easily, as needed
    - Provide subsidies, bonuses, and XPs to businesses
    - Add money to student accounts
    - Push and pause simulation phases forward
        - Trigger activities - e.g.: voting, random scenarios, other

Teacher View

- Should provide end of the day reports
    - Individual student reports
    - Business reports
    - Full simulation report
- Should be easily accessible to teachers via QR code or simple login code

PRODUCT DESIGN REQUIREMENTS

Summary

This document outlines the recommended approach, methodology and experience design best practices and requirements for a successful user experience for all roles involved in the simulation software portion of their flagship Experiential Learning Center, JA BizTown.

A successful agency will take a human-centered design approach employing empathy to arrive at a deep understanding and representation of our audiences by role. They will arrive at an engaging, relevant and easy-to-experience environment where software, experiential flow design and supportive content management systems and user dashboards will work together to create a meaningful and memorable learning experience.

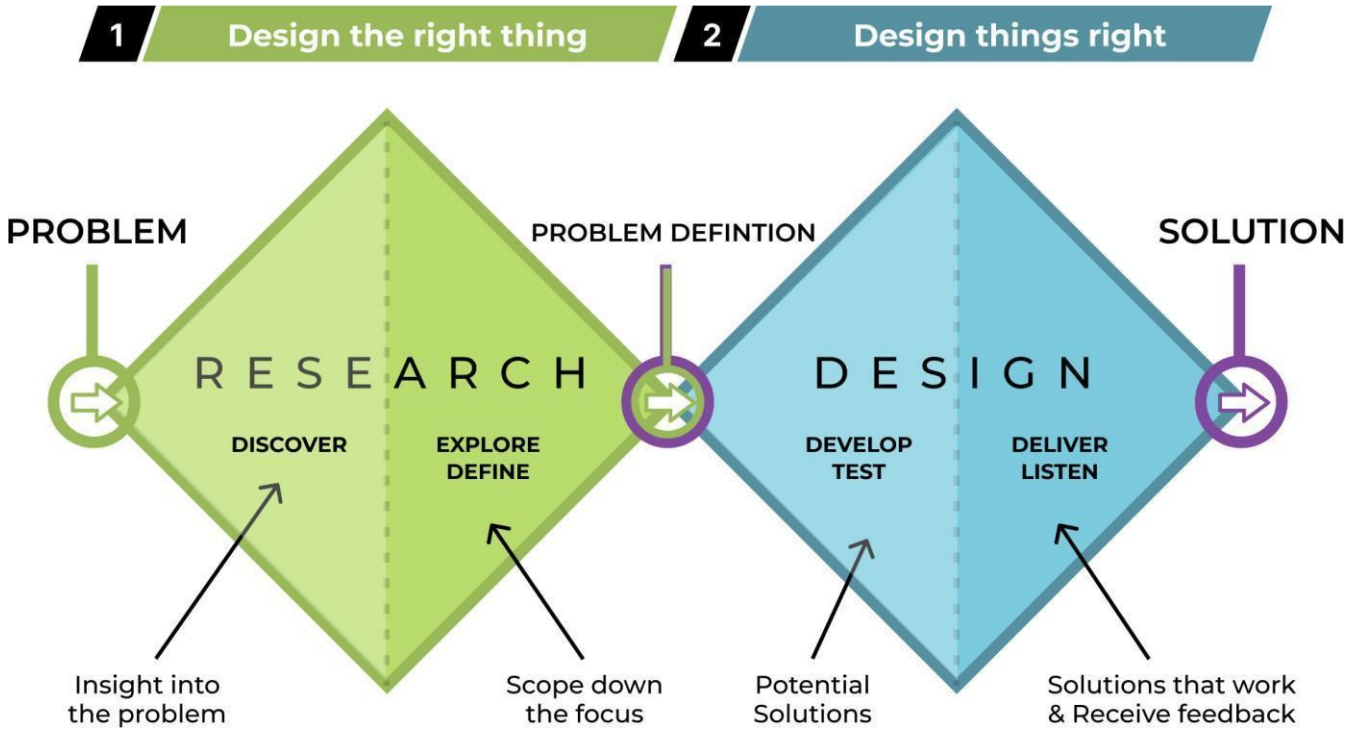
Overview

This document will discuss three portions of the product design approach and deliverables which address the following questions by discipline:

- **User Experience Design:**
  - Are we building the right product features to address the vision and pain points identified for each role? If so, are we building it in a way that is easily adopted, used and accessible?
- **Visual Design:**
  - Are we building an engaging and relevant experience for each role involved? If so, we are clearly adding motivation to move through the experience in a compelling way? Is it aligning with the overall brand of the organization, as well as branding of the product itself?
- **User Experience Research:**
  - Are we checking our solutions early with end users prior to investing too much time and effort into development utilizing Lean Design principles. Are we incorporating feedback into an iterative software design process?

Process & Methodology: Design Thinking

We recommend an approach that takes advantage of the “double diamond” of the Design Thinking approach with a divergence - conference model.



We recommend a "Design / Build" approach where the designers and developers are working together throughout the process. Before diving into detailed code development, it's essential to focus on creating a definition of the behavior as well as low-fidelity clickable wireframes prior to developing a large code base. These elements play a crucial role in the design process by providing a clear understanding of user needs, behaviors, and interactions.

To create a brand-aligned and engaging learning product for tweens/teens, the selected vendor will follow a structured design process that includes the creation of mood boards, style tiles, and user testing. This approach ensures that the final product resonates with the target audience and aligns with our brand identity.

Deliverables by Phase:

The process and deliverables described below are recommended by the in-house Experience Design team. You may have a comparable set of processes and deliverables that arrives at similar goals (answers to the questions indicated above). Either way, we would like to understand your specific deliverables in each phase of your design process. NOTE: Definitions of specific deliverables follow in the Deliverables section below.

- **Research - Discover Phase**
  - While this phase has been done internally by interviewing stakeholders as well as end users, there are some deliverables that will ensure we have a shared understanding of this phase.
  - User Experience
    - **Personas** - at least one per role (See Audience Roles)
    - **User Journeys** - mapped out to show future experience
  - Visual Design

        - **Mood Vision Boards / Style Tiles** - The internal design team will provide branding direction, JA USA color system as well as initial recommendations but we look to you to bring in the overall design direction (in addition to the screens provided in the Phases portion by our Product Management team).
    - User Experience Research
        - **Research Plan** - Identify the specific problems we want to test early in the design process to ensure we are headed in the right direction.
- **Research - Definition Phase**
    - User Experience
        - **User Stories** - These will be the foundation of the functional requirements of the software.
        - **Lo-Fidelity Wireframes** - These black and white key screens which map out the simulation flow from screen-to-screen including the location of key navigation elements as well as interactive components.
        - **Site Maps** - Overview of the entire system of screens per role (for each audience type).
    - Visual Design
        - **Style Guide** - Solidify design approach of all styles and build out template library of Style Guide.
        - **Accessibility Plan** - Document outlining fundamental approach and actions to meet WG 2.1 AA specifically for this software product.
- **Design - Develop & Test Phase**
    - User Experience
        - **Wireframes & Flows** - Finalized, which annotations help the product owners understand which info on the screens are controlled by the CMS, dynamic versus static.
        - **Site maps and navigation structures** - Finalized
    - Visual Design
        - **UI Component System** - Provide list and begin component library of reusable UI components such as buttons, form fields, error handling, etc.
        - **Design Templates** for each screen type
        - **Hi-Fidelity Prototype** of key screens to reflect overall flow (could simply be screens strung together in Figma)
    - User Experience Research
        - **Concept Test:** Conducting usability tests with real users to gather feedback on design and functionality.
- **Design - Deliver & Listen Phase**
    - User Experience
        - **Error Handling / Onboarding** - Document of onscreen user support as well as messaging for when things go wrong.
    - Visual Design
        - **Design Deliverables/Style Guide:** As well as all source files once project complete.
    - User Experience Research
        - **Research Results:** Analyzing test results to identify areas for improvement and ensure the design meets user needs.

Collaboration and Review
Throughout the design process, the vendor will collaborate closely with our team to ensure that we are aligned and seamlessly into the development of the final product. Regular check-ins and reviews will be scheduled to maintain alignment with our brand guidelines and project goals.

Document Deliverables Definitions
It is crucial to ensure that you provide comprehensive documentation and deliverables throughout the design process. These deliverables not only help in tracking progress but also ensure that all stakeholders are aligned with the project's vision and goals.

- **Personas:**
    - Personas are fictional characters created based on research to represent different user types. They help in understanding users' needs, experiences, behaviors, and goals. They ensure we are all on the same page with a user-centered approach.
- **User Stories:**
    - User Stories are short, simple descriptions of a feature told from the perspective of the end user. They help in understanding what the user wants to achieve and why.
    - They provide a clear and concise way to capture user requirements and ensure that the design aligns with user needs and will allow us to prioritize features as a team.
- **User Journeys/Flows:**
    - User Journeys map out the steps a user takes to achieve a specific goal. They help in visualizing the user's experience and identifying potential pain points and opportunities for improvement. User flows that show how real kids will move through the experience
    - They provide a holistic view of the user's interactions with the product, ensuring that the design supports a seamless and intuitive experience.
- **Clickable Low-Fidelity Wireframes:**
    - Low-fidelity wireframes are simplified visual representations of the product's layout and structure. They focus on the basic interactive and dynamic elements without getting into detailed design aspects like color and typography.
    - Clickable wireframes allow for early-stage testing and feedback, helping to validate design concepts and identify issues before investing time and resources into detailed development.
- **Interaction**
    - Animation examples showing how motion will enhance understanding.
- **Three Concept Designs (Via Mood Boards or Style Tiles)**
    - Mood boards are visual representations that capture the essence of the desired look and feel of the product. They include images, colors, typography, and other design elements that convey the intended emotional and aesthetic tone. By presenting mood boards, we can explore different visual directions and gather feedback to refine the overall design concept.
    - Style tiles are more detailed design documents that include color palettes, typography choices, button styles, and other UI components. They are a bridge between the abstract ideas in mood boards and the concrete design specifications needed for development.
- **Design & Style Guides:**
    - High-fidelity mockups and prototypes demonstrating the visual design and interaction patterns bring the platform to life visually.
    - Style guides and design systems that ensure consistency across the product, including reusable UI components that captures the personality of JA BizTown
    - Final Source Files - in layered files that can be used by the internal design team (Figma preferred).
- **Image Specifications & Tracking**
    - Image Tracking - we will provide an image tracker as well as access to our photo libraries

for use in the sim.

- **Usability Test Plans and Reports:**
  - Plans detailing the methodology for usability testing, including participant recruitment and test scenarios.
  - Reports summarizing the results of usability tests and recommendations for improvements.
- **Final Deliverables:**
  - Comprehensive documentation of the final design, including all assets and specifications.
  - Source Files - All layered source files must be provided to JAUSA should a change need to be made in the future.

Product Design Expectations

Responsive Design

The interface should be responsive and adapt to different screen sizes and orientations, ensuring a seamless experience across various tablet models.

Accessibility

The design should comply with accessibility standards (e.g., WCAG) to ensure that all users, including those with disabilities, can access and interact with the content. (See Technical section).

Touch-Friendly Controls

Design controls and buttons that are touch-friendly and easy to interact with on a tablet screen.

Engaging Visuals

The learning experience should include engaging visuals, such as images, videos, and animations, to enhance understanding and retention of information.

Interactive Elements

Incorporate interactive elements to make the learning experience more engaging and participatory

Build virtual stores and banks where kids practice every day financial tasks

Give them business tools that feel like the real thing but with training wheels (e.g. age-appropriate point of sale system will be simple and to the point)

Clear Instructions

Provide clear and concise instructions for each activity or module to ensure users understand what is expected of them.

Immediate Feedback

The system should provide immediate feedback on user actions, such as quiz answers or activity completions, to reinforce learning and guide users.

Progress Tracking

Include a progress tracker that allows users to see their advancement through the learning modules and understand their overall progress.

Immersive Design (Animation/Motion)

Don't just tell kids about compound interest – show them with animations that make the concept click

Add those little animated moments of delight when something goes right (or wrong)

Break down complex ideas into step-by-step animated tutorials

Focused Approach

Adopt a design approach to avoid clutter and focus on essential elements, making the interface clean and easy to navigate. Make it clear where to focus attention – financial concepts can be complex, so visual hierarchy matters and clear “calls-to-actions” are essential.

Personalization

Personalization will include features such as customizable dashboards, user-specific recommendations, and adaptive content.

Proximity

Proximity refers to the strategic placement of related tasks or functions close to one another within the interface. When users can easily find and access related functions, it reduces cognitive load and minimizes the time spent navigating the platform.

Persistence:

Persistence is the practice of maintaining the state of user selections and preferences across sessions and interactions. When users know that their settings and choices will be preserved, it builds trust and reduces frustration. Persistence can be achieved through features such as saved preferences, session continuity, and state retention.

Intuitive Navigation Patterns

The learning experience should have a clear and intuitive navigation system that allows users to easily find and access different sections and features.

Clear differentiation between the various steps so that it doesn't look/feel like students are doing the same thing over and over again.

UI Patterns

Reduce long scrolling screens and chuck content to reduce cognitive load.

Ensure content is short bite-sized snippets like shopping "Quickviews"

Utilize real-world interface experiences - like shopping online; don't reinvent NEW navigation patterns but use ones that students are already familiar with.

SCOPE OF WORK

The following reflect the scope of work required to launch simulation:

- Build front-end student simulation based on requirements defined by Junior Achievement
- Build content management system (CMS)
    - Paper-based solution (CMS takes simulation data and prints out data as PDFs)
- Simulation dashboards
    - Staff Sim Manager
    - Educator/Volunteer

Assumptions:

- Build a unified software framework to support the onsite JA BizTown experience

Key Project Milestones

Estimate Project Deadlines	**Start**	**End**
Vendor Volunteers In-Person for a JA BizTown Simulation	May 2026	May 2026
Project Kickoff (in person JA USA and Vendor)	May 2026	June 2026
Design & Software Development	May 2026	May 2027
Clickable prototype for user testing	Sep 2026	Oct 2026
Pilot Release Ready	Jan 2027	Mar 2027
JA Area Training & Site Prep*	Nov 2026	Dec 2026
Pilot Testing (JA Areas)	Jan 2027	Mar 2027
Updates	Mar 2027	Jun 2027
Final testing	Apr 2027	Jun 2027
Final training documentation		Jun 2027
Initial Release		Jun 2027

*Video trailer training and pilot documents ideal

TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS

Summary

- **Overview**: This document outlines the preferred technical requirements for JA USA's new software project. While specific technologies are recommended, deviations are acceptable if the developer can demonstrate a proven and effective approach.

Infrastructure

- **Cloud Platform**: The project will be hosted on **Microsoft Azure**, leveraging its robust cloud services to ensure scalability, reliability, and security. Azure's comprehensive suite of tools and services will support the development, deployment, and management of the application.
- **Database**: The application will utilize **SQL Server** for its database needs, providing a powerful, reliable, and secure database management system that integrates seamlessly with Azure.
- **Ownership and Management**: The product will be owned, managed, hosted, and supported by **JA USA**.

Mobile Application Development

- **Framework**: The mobile application will be developed using **.NET Core** for the backend and **React Native** for the frontend.
- **Design**: The application will follow a **mobile-first design** approach, ensuring optimal performance and user experience on mobile devices. A bootstrapper framework, such as Bootstrap or a similar library, will be used to streamline the design process and ensure responsiveness across different screen sizes.
- **Deployment**: The React Native app will be deployed using **Expo.dev**, a platform that simplifies the deployment process and allows for the creation of native iOS and Android apps. Expo.dev provides tools and services to build, deploy, and manage the app efficiently, ensuring it meets the requirements of both the Apple App Store and Google Play Store.

Backend Development

- **Architecture**: The backend will be designed using a **microservices architecture**. This approach breaks down the application into smaller, independent services that can be developed, deployed, and scaled individually. **Containers** will be utilized as part of the deployment and scalability strategy, allowing for consistent environments across development, testing, and production. Containers facilitate efficient resource utilization and simplify the deployment process.
- L**anguage**: The backend services will be written in **C# .NET Core**, utilizing .NET 8.0 or .NET 9.0 as the primary code framework.
- **Database Queries**: All database queries will be implemented using **stored procedures**. Stored procedures help optimize performance by taking advantage of cached execution

plans, reducing the overhead of query parsing and compilation.

Frontend Development

- **Framework**: The frontend will be developed using **React Native**.
- **Design**: The frontend will adhere to a **mobile-first design** philosophy, ensuring that the user interface is optimized for mobile devices. A bootstrapper framework will be used to ensure responsiveness and consistency across different screen sizes and devices.
- **Design Pattern**: The frontend design pattern will be a **single-page application (SPA)**. This approach eliminates page reloads and refreshes, maintaining student engagement by providing a faster and more seamless user experience.
- **Responsive Web Design**: The application will implement the three key technical features of responsive web design to ensure cross-mobile device compatibility:
- **Media Queries and Media Query Listeners**: Designed with a mobile-first layout.
- **Flexible Grid-Based Layout**: Uses relative sizing.
- **Flexible Images and Media**: Through dynamic resizing or CSS.

Paper-based Version

- **Purpose**: In case of circumstances beyond the control of the facility (e.g. power/internet outages), a paper-based version of the simulation must be an option.
- **What's Included**: Complete simulations to allow students to have a complete experience without the use of the mobile app.

Accessibility

- **Standards**: The application must meet **AA** compliance with the **Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2 AA** standards. This ensures that the app is accessible to users with disabilities, providing an inclusive user experience.
- **Documentation**: Comprehensive documentation of all accessibility features and practices will be provided. This documentation will detail how the app meets WCAG standards and will be essential for ensuring compliance in the event of a legal audit.
- **VPAT**: The vendor is expected to provide a **Voluntary Product Accessibility Template (VPAT)** for each theme or section of the application to demonstrate how it conforms to the WCAG guidelines.

Security Data

- **Privacy:** The application must adhere to stringent data privacy standards to protect user information. This includes implementing best practices for data encryption, secure data storage, and user consent management.
- **Standards Compliance**: The product shall adhere to conventional **IETF, OWASP, and W3C standards** for web applications to ensure security, interoperability, and accessibility.
- **Student Authentication**: Student authentication should be quick and require minimal interaction with their device. This could include methods such as **QR code** scanning or **PIN**

entry, provided to the student at the start of the simulation. Authentication should not be tied to the device to allow for device swaps during the simulation.

- **Non-Student Authentication**: Staff, teacher, and volunteer authentication will be managed through **Microsoft's Entra B2C**. The application will also incorporate **OpenID** to allow authentication through additional means.
- **Documentation**: Detailed documentation of all security measures, including data privacy and standards compliance, will be provided. This documentation will outline the steps taken to ensure security and will be crucial for demonstrating compliance during a legal audit.

Scalability

- **Concurrent Users**: The application must be designed to support upwards of **5,000 concurrent users**. Given that the app is a simulation that will run for several hours, it is crucial to ensure that all 5,000 users can use the app simultaneously without performance degradation.
- **Performance Optimization**: The backend services will be optimized for high performance, utilizing **Azure's scalable infrastructure** to handle the load. This includes auto-scaling features to dynamically allocate resources based on demand, ensuring consistent performance even during peak usage.
- **Load Balancing**: Implementing **load balancing** strategies will distribute incoming traffic across multiple servers, preventing any single server from becoming a bottleneck. This will enhance the application's reliability and responsiveness.
- **Database Performance**: SQL Server will be configured to handle high volumes of transactions efficiently. Using **stored procedures** will further optimize database performance by leveraging cached execution plans and reducing query processing time.
- **Microservices Architecture**: The use of a **microservices architecture** will allow individual services to be scaled independently. This modular approach ensures that specific components can be scaled up or down based on usage patterns, providing greater flexibility and resource efficiency.
- **Monitoring and Alerts**: Continuous monitoring of the application's performance will be implemented using Azure's monitoring tools. Real-time alerts will be set up to detect and respond to any performance issues promptly, ensuring minimal downtime and optimal user experience.
- **National Data Handling**: The application must be capable of handling total national data from **500-600K students** in a 9-month school year. The database architecture must be scalable over time.

Boards and Source Control

- **Azure DevOps:** The project will use Azure DevOps to track work items, wiki documentation, source control, automated test plans, and pipelines for builds and releases. The Azure DevOps project will be hosted by JA USA.
- **Work Items**: Work items should be grouped by **Epics and Features** with individual work items

in **User Stories and Bugs**. User Stories and Bugs cannot be worked until refined into a **Ready to Work** state.

- **Source Control**: Source control will use **Git** within Azure DevOps. The Git workflow should be modeled off of **Gitflow** or another popular and documented workflow strategy for Git. All commits and pull requests to the code repository must include informative comments about the code changes. Git should be utilized for all source code including the database, backend, and frontend.
- **Code Review**: Code review should be performed and documented before any **Pull Request** is approved. All Pull Requests must be associated with a User Story or Bug. All Pull Requests must be code reviewed before both being merged into the primary branch and before being made available for testing to the product owners.
- **Automated Test Plans**: Automated Test Plans should be used to test as many Feature level functions as possible.
- **Automated Builds**: Automated builds using pipelines should occur to prove out all code merges.

Agile Methodology

- **Scrum**: The preferred methodology for Agile development is Scrum. A standard sprint length should be determined based on what the development team finds suitable for the work and staffing.
- **Work Item Sizing**: The development team should decide on the most effective method of effort estimation and communicate this to JA to set expectations.
- **Sprint Meetings**: The development team will collaborate with JA to establish a cadence of scrum meetings during the course of a sprint. These should include:
    - Pre-Sprint Planning
    - Stand-up
    - Refinement
    - Retrospective
    - Review/Demo

Deployment

- **Release Pipelines**: Release pipelines will be used for all deployments. The release pipeline will need to be automated to work with an **Azure Web App** for the .NET Core microservices and with **Expo.dev** for the React Native frontend.
- **Multi-Platform Deployment**: The application should be deployed as a mobile application for both **Android and iOS devices** as well as being deployed as a **web application**. The React Native app will be deployed using **Expo.dev** to the Apple App Store and Google Play Store.
- **App Updates**: The application should use over-the-air updates through Expo.dev to push immediate app updates to all student tablets. Additionally, the application should be able to check the app store at startup to see if a new version is available.

Administrative Capabilities

- **Content Management System (CMS)**: The product will include administrative capabilities to

manage and monitor the application effectively. A CMS will be provided for JA staff to modify features of the application. Each facility running a simulation will have the ability to modify the features of their simulation. There will be two simulations as part of this project targeted at different audiences of students. Each facility should have the ability to manage multiple templates for both simulation types from the CMS.

- **Dashboards**: Staff, teachers, and volunteers will need access to dashboards to monitor the simulation while students are using it. Feature sets will vary by user type and will include status and metrics of the simulation as a whole, with the ability to drill down into individual students. The dashboard will allow users to make updates to the live simulation, such as moving a student to the next phase and awarding XP. Dashboards will also include post-simulation surveys for users.
- **Admin App**: A decision will be made on whether the administrative capabilities should be contained in a separate app or as part of the student app behind a login.
- **Local Sponsorship Updates**: The product will include local sponsorship update capabilities via the cloud, with each local JA BizTown facility having unique sponsorship update requirements.

Support and Maintenance

- **Continuing Support Arrangement**: The vendor will propose a continuing support arrangement anticipating an annual upgrade/revision cycle.
- **Performance Standards**: Performance standards will be determined by the interactivity of the application, recognizing that student engagement is dramatically impacted by system response time. The user experience will be used as the acceptance criteria when evaluating the performance of the application.
- **Infrastructure Proposal**: The vendor is expected to propose an infrastructure required to support and scale the application. An architecture review will be conducted upon receipt of proposals, prior to development.

Localization

- **Language Translation**: The product needs to be programmed and designed to be easily translated into additional languages. This should include English and Spanish translations in XLF files. The future expansion of additional language XLF files should be supported.
- **Browser-based Translations**: All onscreen text and alt text descriptions of images and other assets need to be accessible by browser-based translation services. On-screen text containers should be expandable to accommodate varying amounts of characters, as translations can change the character count.

Reporting

- **Student Data**: All student-related data should be reportable. This includes all data entered about a student, all student interactions with the simulation, and all staff, teacher, and volunteer interactions with a student. Every step a student takes through the simulation should be a reportable event to aid in reporting metrics and troubleshooting.

- **CMS Data**: All changes to the simulation through the CMS should be tracked. A history of every change, including what was changed and by whom, should be tracked for reporting, troubleshooting, and audit purposes.

- **Dashboard Data**: All changes to a live simulation through one of the dashboard interfaces should be tracked. A history of the change, including the action taken and the user, should be tracked for reporting and troubleshooting.
- **Azure**: All toolsets available through JA's Azure portal should be utilized. This includes Application Insights, logs, custom events, exceptions, and more.

- **Power BI**: All student data should be available to Power BI for internal JA reporting needs.

Proof of Concept

- **Initial Proof of Concept**: An initial proof of concept of the mobile application using the specified technologies should be made available to JA as soon as possible to ensure proper adoption of the technology stack.

- **Follow-up Proofs of Concept**: Follow-up proofs of concept regarding the CMS and dashboards should follow.

Documentation

- **End User Documentation**: Provide end user documentation, including administration manuals and train-the-trainer sessions. Documentation needs to cover all administrative tools to set up a new location, categories, sponsors, daily simulations, and any other admin functionality. Step-by-step instructions, in a logical order, to walk a facility through setting up and configuring a new simulation in the CMS. Include day-of-simulation troubleshooting guides for using the application.

- **Engineering Documentation**: Provide comprehensive engineering documentation and data schema. Documentation should include all aspects of setting up environments across all technical platforms used for development and delivery. This should be structured in a way to support disaster recovery efforts.

Eligible Applicants

- Proposals are invited from US-based companies with employees demonstrating experience and capacity in managing and executing six-figure projects involving an interplay of:
    - RWD-based cross-platform mobile device development
    - CMS selection and/or creation and implementation
    - .NET Framework architecture
    - MS SQL Server database solutions
    - Mobile app development
    - Ongoing technical support
    - User Experience / Service Blueprint Design
    - Interaction & User Interface design
    - Visual design (all aspects including layout, illustrations, photography etc.)

- Experience in developing educational solutions is desirable.

SCOPE & PRICING

The primary goal and scope of this RFP is to determine vendor capabilities in providing a solution for this project. **Pricing** is to be provided in the accompanying vendor response.

PROCESS

JA is looking for written capabilities for the information provided in this RFP. Written responses to this RFP should demonstrate how the vendor would meet JA's requirements to update the current simulation and build out the new functions and features. Please provide detailed pricing for the level of effort. Please also include relevant work experience. All responses are requested via email.

PROPOSAL SCHEDULE & SUBMISSION PROCEDURES

Below are the milestones for the RFP process. Vendors that fail to meet the timelines may be disqualified from the process at JA's discretion.

Step	Date Due
RFP Distributed by JA	3/13/2026
Vendors email JA USA with confirmation that they will participate in the proposal process (email to Jeannine.reilly@ja.org and julian.arias@ja.org).	3/18/2026
Vendor Submits Questions to JA (email to Jeannine.reilly@ja.org and julian.arias@ja.org) Note: Questions should be delivered as a numbered list sent in the body of an email. The email subject must be 'JABT 3.0 RFP Questions'	3/20/2026
JA Response to Questions Distributed to Vendors	3/27/2026
Proposals Due to JA Electronically (email to Jeannine.reilly@ja.org and julian.arias@ja.org)	4/10/2026
JA Reviews proposals (selects top vendors for interviews)	4/13/2026-4/17/2026
Proposal Interviews Scheduled with Vendors (if required)	4/20/2026-4/24/2026
Selection of Vendor	4/27/2026-5/1/2026
Contract Terms Negotiated (MSA)	5/1/2026-5/15/2026
Work Begins	May

Period of Irrevocability. Proposals will be offers that are irrevocable for a period of sixty (60) days after the time and date proposals are due. Proposals will contain the name, address and telephone number of an individual or individuals with authority to bind the company during the period in which the proposal will be evaluated.

EVALUATION PROCEDURES

Proposal Content and Evaluation Criteria

Proposals should be prepared simply and economically, providing a straightforward, concise description of the proposer's ability to satisfy the requirements of this RFP. Submissions of technical literature, display charts, or other supplemental materials are the responsibility and within the discretion of the proposer. JA will not be liable for any expense incurred in the preparation of proposals.

Proposals will be evaluated by JA's evaluation team based upon the criteria indicated by the content outline below. Although some of the criteria may be given more weight than others, each proposer is expected to provide a comprehensive proposal which allows JA to do a complete evaluation against the criteria. All proposals should be submitted using the JA template provided.

1. **Executive Overview**

   - ☐ Provide the name, title, mailing address, direct phone number and email address for personnel responsible for answering questions and scheduling meetings regarding the proposal.
   - ☐ Organization Financial and Contract Information
   - ☐ High-level overview of your proposal, stating your interest in and qualifications for this project.
   - ☐ Discuss how your company is positioned to succeed through the following:
     - Mission, vision, values, goals and strategy
     - Company ownership – private, public, etc.
     - People – number of people, skills, experience
     - Areas of expertise – capabilities and specific skills relevant to the requirements of this RFP
   - ☐ Briefly provide up to three project examples of similar size and scope to JA's project that demonstrate your company's experience and capability providing resources relevant to the requirements of this RFP. Provide client contact information for each example.

2. **Staffing**

   Discuss your engagement staffing strategy and the proposed engagement team, including resumes of key staff.

3. **Approach**

   Provide an overview of how you intend to structure and manage the workflow of the entire project. In specific, please outline your intended approach to the various elements of the entire project:

   - ☐ UX, Visual Design and Prototype Testing process
   - ☐ Software development process
   - ☐ User Experience/Design team process and engagement with the Engineering/Dev team
   - ☐ User testing process
   - ☐ Quality Assurance process
   - ☐ Project management process
   - ☐ Source code control procedures
   - ☐ Training and documentation

- ☐ Ongoing requirements and costs for the solution once the application has launched
- ☐ Warranties

4. **Design Evaluation Criteria**

We'll be evaluating the following criteria:

- Evidence you understand how to design for kids at different ages
- Application of student friendly approach to real world business software. Kids love to role play. The. CEOS often show up in suits and that their role seriously. The CMOs tend to be the creative types. The CFO math folks. Ensure that is reflected in the UI experience to increase engagement
- Technical chops to pull off simple relevant structured experiences as well as sophisticated interactions
- A track record with animation that actually teaches, not just decorates
- Realistic project planning that won't leave us hanging
- Ability to collab with in- house design team without feeling like toes are stepped on
- Ability to show decisions and flows with wires prior to fully designed screens.
- Show us examples of educational platforms you've created, especially ones that show you understand this audience. We want JA BizTown to be the place where business roles and business management clicks for students, not just another educational requirement they endure.

5. **Schedule**

As stated in the section above, we hope to have a functioning Beta for pilot testing for January 2027 with intention of launching the product (initial release) the summer of 2027 (June). Please provide a set of suggested milestones for achieving these general deadlines. Also outline risk mitigation procedures in the event of un-planned project delays. Note that JA testing requires releasing builds to our advisory group local areas for testing with the students. This feedback is gathered and applied to updating and ensuring a strong product release.

6. **Cost/Fees**

Provide pricing listing staff roles and associated costs or proposed charges for each role. Please provide a reasonable and realistic estimate of the total cost range of this project.

Interviews

Selected proposers may be invited to participate in an interview stage of the evaluation process. Proposers should be prepared to respond to questions related specifically to their proposals and other pertinent matters with respect to the RFP. If Interviews are needed they will be scheduled by JA USA once the proposals are received.

ADDITIONAL DETAILS

This RFP does not guarantee that a participating respondent will be selected.

JA reserves the right to award the project or any subset thereof, and to reject any and all proposals received. Until an award is issued, no communication by the JA or its representatives, whether written

or oral, shall be interpreted as a promise that an award will be made. Services shall be rendered pursuant to a separate written contract with JA.

JA is not offering an exclusive agreement and may contract with more than one party for services.

PROPRIETARY/CONFIDENTIAL INFORMATION

Respondents are bound to the provisions of the mutual non-disclosure agreement already signed.

OWNERSHIP

All materials for both draft and final products are to be considered the sole property of Junior Achievement USA.

APPENDIX

The Day in the Town (Current State)

Student:

Step	Activity	Description
1	High-Energy Welcome	The day kicks off with an energetic student welcome to get everyone excited and ready for the immersive experience ahead.
2	Welcome and Orientation	JA staff welcome the students to JA BizTown and orient them to the space and what they will be doing in the town for the day.
3	Business Start-Up	Students begin reading through their job tasks. CFOs will complete payroll and apply for their business loan. CEOs begin practicing their opening town meeting speech. All students meet their volunteer for the day.
4	Opening Town Meeting	CEOs will give their speeches to their fellow citizens sharing what their business will be doing today.
5	Lunch Break Rotations (facility dependent)	Students take turns going on their lunch break. Students who are not eating lunch will be working in their business on their list of job tasks.
6	Staff Meeting	The CEO will lead the meeting and discuss with their team how much of the business loan they have paid off and discuss any strategies for the rest of the day.
7	Shopping Break Rotations	Like lunch break rotations, students will take turns going on their shopping break. Students use the money they have earned during the day to make purchases at the various businesses in JA BizTown. Students who are not shopping will continue working.
8	Business Clean-Up	Students clean up their space and return any items to their designated spot.
9	Closing Town Meeting	One or more CEOs may give a closing town meeting speech at this time.
10	Dismissal	Students are dismissed to their buses.

Note: The structure of the JA BizTown day will most likely be modified.

Staff:

Step	Activity	Description
1	Simulation Setup	The day begins with the simulation manager activating the simulation in the JA BizTown CMS (typically the simulation manager creates the simulation before the actual simulation day). Staff will also log onto all devices (tablets, laptops, etc.).
2	Volunteer Training	Next, the simulation manager conducts a volunteer training

		session. During this session, they teach volunteers how to facilitate group discussions and guide students through the simulation. • Provide volunteers with a walkthrough of the simulation, showing them the student view and how to use the simulation guide to assist students. • Ensure volunteers understand their roles and feel confident in supporting students throughout the day.
3	Preparing for Students	Once the volunteer training is complete, the simulation manager prepares for the students' arrival. This includes: • Setting up the physical space (e.g., storefronts, student materials, etc.). • Double-checking that all devices and systems are ready for use.
4	High-Energy Welcome	When the students arrive, the simulation manager kicks off the day with a high-energy welcome to get everyone excited and engaged. They explain the day's activities and set the tone for an interactive and fun learning experience.
5	Facilitating the Simulation	Throughout the day, the simulation manager: • Makes announcements to guide students through each portion of the day (e.g., Business Start-Up, Lunch Break Rotations, Shopping Break Rotations, etc.) • Monitors the progress of students, ensuring the simulation runs smoothly and seamlessly. • Troubleshoots any technical issues or questions that arise, providing support to both students and volunteers.
6	Wrapping Up	At the end of the simulation, the simulation manager guides the students through the Closing Town Meeting and assists the lead educator with the dismissal process. They also thank the volunteers and gather feedback to improve future simulations.

<u>Volunteer</u>:

Step	Activity	Description
1	Arrival	Volunteers arrive at the facility and are checked in by JA staff.
2		
3	High-Energy Welcome	The day kicks off with an energetic student welcome to get everyone excited and ready for the immersive experience

		ahead.
4	Welcome and Orientation	JA Staff welcomes the students to the space and explains what they will be doing during the simulation. The volunteers are listening either in their storefronts or in town square.
5	Business Start-Up	Students begin reading through their job tasks, CFOs will complete payroll and apply for their business loan. CEOs begin practicing their opening town meeting speech. The volunteer will introduce themselves to the students and assist them with getting acclimated to their space.
6	Opening Town Meeting	CEOs will give their speeches to their fellow citizens sharing what their business will be doing today. The volunteers will be listening to the town meeting.
7	Lunch Break Rotations	Students take turns going on their lunch break. Students who are not eating lunch will be working on their job tasks with the support of their volunteer.
8	Staff Meeting	The CEO will lead the meeting and discuss with their team how much of the business loan they have paid off and any strategies for the rest of the day. The volunteer will not lead this meeting, but will support where needed.
9	Shopping Break Rotations	Like lunch breaks, students take turns going on their shopping break. Students use the money they have earned during the day to make purchases at various businesses in JA BizTown. Students who are not shopping will continue working with the support of their volunteer.
10	Business Clean-Up	Students clean up their space and return any items to their designated spot. Volunteers will collect any items that need to be returned (debit cards, cash, lanyards, etc.).
11	Closing Town Meeting	One or more CEOs may give a closing town meeting speech. Volunteers will observe the final portion of the day.
12	Dismissal	Students are dismissed to their buses. Volunteers will receive a final thank you from JA staff and have an opportunity to provide feedback.

Teachers:

Teachers follow the same schedule as above for students, staff, and volunteers. Teachers primary responsibilities are to check for student understanding and to maintain proper student behavior.

Teachers also may serve as a business volunteer if necessary and generally support the learning of the students throughout the day.

CHARACTER EDUCATION

The Lilly Endowment has granted JA USA with a grant to update its Learning Experiences (LE) with Character Education. Lilly Endowment Inc. (LEI) is a private foundation based in Indianapolis, created in 1937 by J.K. Lilly, Sr. and his sons – Eli and J.K. Jr. – through gifts of stock in their pharmaceutical business, Eli Lilly and Company. LEI is a completely separate entity from Eli Lilly and Company and operates independently. LEI has a long history of supporting community development, religion and education in Indiana and throughout the United States, recognizing that youth-serving organizations are essential in helping youth and their families thrive.

Character education is essential for students because it cultivates the integrity, resilience,

and social responsibility necessary for success in both life and the workforce. Students must develop ethical decision-making, teamwork, and perseverance—skills that drive personal achievement and contribute to a strong economy. Character education encourages a positive school culture, reduces disciplinary issues, and enhances academic performance, preparing students to become responsible citizens and adaptable professionals in a rapidly evolving job market. By promoting values like leadership, empathy, and accountability, character education not only benefits individual students but also strengthens communities and fuels long-term economic growth.

JA is committed to intentionally **integrating and amplifying** character-driven behaviors and traits to ensure that students are taught positive character traits and have ample opportunities to practice and embody them in JA learning experiences. JA's Character Model includes a definition of character and character education, along with specific positive character traits to ensure alignment and measurement across our learning experiences.

Character is a composite of cognitive, emotional, and motivational traits, evidenced by behaviors that foster personal growth, benefit others, and contribute to the greater community.

Character education involves cultivating character explicitly and implicitly through educational activities that build young people's skills, abilities, and mindset.

It is important to note that these specific traits are aligned to Self, Others, and Community. Developing character traits goes beyond the individual; we nurture future leaders and changemakers who will inspire others and creative positive transformations within their communities.

JA's instructional approach to teaching and developing character leverages research-backed best practices from the Jubilee Centre Framework for Character Education in Schools with instructional strategies developed by Wake Forest University.

The Jubilee Centre's Framework:

The program for Leadership and Character at Wake Forest University's 7 Strategies:

1. Habituation through practice (Practice) 2. Reflection on personal experience (Reflection) 3. Engaging with virtuous exemplars (Role models) 4. Dialogue that increases virtue literacy (Language)	5. Awareness of situational variables and biases (Systems) 6. Moral reminders (Reminders) 7. Friendships of mutual accountability (Friendships)

Character Education Moments in Simulation

- **Honesty in Business Transactions and Reporting:** Students experience the importance of honesty by accurately recording transactions, reporting revenue and expenses, and approving payroll and invoices, understanding that transparency builds trust within a business and the broader community.

- **Responsibility for Business Resources:** Students learn to respect shared business resources by making thoughtful decisions about product pricing, inventory, staffing, and loan usage, recognizing that poor stewardship impacts a business's sustainability.

- **Accountability for Financial Decisions:** JA BizTown reinforces accountability by requiring students to approve and authorize business decisions, such as paying bills and selling products, understanding that choices have real outcomes.

- **Ethical Business Practices and Fair Dealing:** Students are encouraged to engage in fair, ethical transactions with other businesses and citizens, learning that ethical behavior supports long-term success and community trust.

- **Thoughtful Use of Credit and Loans:** JA BizTown teaches responsible borrowing by helping students understand loans and encouraging them to work towards paying off their loans.

- **Balancing Individual Success with Community Impact:** JA BizTown emphasizes that business decisions affect more than just individual roles, encouraging students to consider the health of the town and its institutions.

- **Integrity in Role-Based Responsibilities and Value:** Students learn that different roles carry different responsibilities, and that fulfilling one's role ethically contributes to overall success and value.

- **Citizenship Through Economic Participation:** Students experience the role of responsible businesses in supporting the broader community through participation in shared systems

(paying taxes).

Area JA BizTown Videos (examples):

Junior Achievement of Georgia - What is JA BizTown?
Junior Achievement of Western PA (Pittsburgh) - https://youtu.be/iSbdmmsIogQ
Junior Achievement of Eastern Iowa (Cedar Rapids) - https://youtu.be/oTOgBGR3E94?si=o7yl7TKKV9_nMk–
Junior Achievement of Georgia - Workforce Development and Impact - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mP9a85K6nws
Junior Achievement of Georgia - Discovery Center - https://youtu.be/JfFDb2DlKuI?si=4rw6POqtm25BaoRi